A PLAYFUL COAST

Tamil Nadu's beautiful coastline offers a slew of watersports and coastal tourism experiences





Tamil Nadu has always been known for its gorgeous beaches lining India's eastern coast. In recent years, the long coastline has also emerged as an exciting hub for watersports.

Kovalam or Covelong Beach near Chennai received the prestigious Blue Flag tag from the Denmark Environment Agency in September 2021. The coveted certification was awarded for the beach's cleanliness, green cover, eco-friendly management practices, and excellent visitor facilities like safe swimming zone, loungers and hammocks and outdoor fitness equipment. Kovalam is also a major centre for surfing, and is home to a world-class surfing school. A surfing and yoga festival is organized on the beach here annually.

Rameswaram, which lies next to the Gulf of Mannar Biosphere Reserve, is another major watersports destination. Exciting activities like scuba diving and snorkelling are offered in the gulf's pristine waters. The coral reefs here teem with colourful fish and an astonishing variety of marine fauna. Those who can't swim can still peek into this wet wonderland by opting for a ride in a glass-bottomed boat to the reefs. The excellent wind conditions in Rameswaram have made it a popular haunt for kite surfing enthusiasts.

Another major coastal centre for adventure activities in Tamil Nadu is Thoothukudi or Tuticorin. Visitors can indulge in activities like kayaking and canoeing, scuba diving, snorkelling, as well as surfing and kitesurfing here. Wakeboarding, stand-up paddle boarding and fishing are some of the activities on offer. Thoothukudi also boasts a stellar watersports academy. Apart from adventure sports, this pearl-fishing centre has the Panimaya Matha Church built by the Portuguese in 1711 and the stunning-looking Manapad Beach.

Indeed, the entire Tamil Nadu coast is lined with beautiful beaches which invite visitors for an adventure or to just lounge about and watch the waves roll in. Major beaches of the state include Marina Beach—the longest urban beach—and the Edward Elliot's Beach of Chennai. Just 60 kilometres south of Chennai is Mamallapuram. It's not only home to beautiful stretches of sand but also the world-famous Shore Temple, setting of the annual Mamallapuram International Dance Festival. The temple, along with Arjuna's Penance, one of the largest open-air rock reliefs in the world, and the monolithic chariot-shaped temples (Pancha Rathas), comprises a group of monuments which are a UNESCO World Heritage Site.

Other highlights of the Tamil Nadu coast include the mangroves of Pichavaram; the ancient port city of Poompuhar; the Chola-era settlement of Nagapattinam which boasts Chudamani Vihara, an important Buddhist structure, as well as a British-era lighthouse; the former Danish settlement of Tharangambadi; and Kanniyakumari, the southernmost tip of mainland India.

Tamil Nadu is a land of vibrant cultures, spellbound attractions, and memorable journeys. It is truly a destination where stories never end.



